

Glossary

a cappella

Unaccompanied vocal performance.

accent

A stress on a particular note or beat.

accompaniment

A musical part that supports the lead instrument or vocal part.

acoustic

An instrument that does not use electrical amplification, or the music such an instrument produces.

alto

The highest of the broken male voices and lowest of the female voices. An instrument lower in pitch than a treble instrument.

aria

A solo vocal piece in an opera or an oratorio.

arpeggio

A chord in which the notes are played separately.

arrangement

The adaptation of a piece of music for different instruments or voices.

articulation

The technique used by a musician to affect the length a note is sounded for, or the transition between notes.

atonal

Describes music without a recognizable key.

badinerie

In 18th-century music, a light instrumental piece.

bar

A segment of time containing a fixed number of beats. Also called a measure.

baritone

The male voice between tenor and bass. An instrument sounding within this range.

Baroque

The period between 1600 and 1750.

bass

The lowest of the male voices. The lowest part of a chord or piece of music.

basso continuo

See continuo

beat

The basic unit of time from which a rhythm is built.

blue note

A flattened note—usually the third, fifth, or seventh—in a scale, often used by blues and jazz musicians.

bow

A long, thin piece of wood with horsehair stretched along it, used to play string instruments. Used as a verb, it means to play with a bow.

break

A short, improvised or sharply contrasting passage or pause in a piece of music..

bridge

In a piece of music, a passage that makes a transition from one section to another. On a string instrument, the upright piece of wood over which the strings are stretched.

broken chord

A chord in which the notes are each played in turn.

cadence

The closing sequence of a musical phrase or composition.

cadenza

A passage within a concerto designed to show off the soloist's skill. Usually unaccompanied.

caesura

A pause in a piece of music.

call-and-response

A musical phrase in which the first part is answered by a second part, often played or sung by a different musician.

canon

A piece in which separate voices or instruments enter one by one, repeating the same melody.

cantata

A piece of music for solo voices, choir, and orchestra, usually in several movements.

cantor

The leader of a choir.

chamber music

Music for small groups of two or more instruments, such as duets, trios, and quartets.

chanson

Medieval or Renaissance French part-song. Later came to refer to any song to French lyrics.

chord

Any simultaneous combination of notes.

chorus

A group of singers. A piece of choral music. Part of a song that follows the verse.

chromatic

Based on the scale of all 12 half steps in an octave.

Classical

The period between 1750 and 1820. Also used (with a lower case c: classical) as a general term

meaning Western music intended for a formal context, as opposed to popular music.

clavier

An old-fashioned word meaning keyboard instrument.

clef

A sign placed at the beginning of a musical staff to indicate the pitch of the notes on the staff.

coda

A final section of a piece, often distinct from the overall structure.

concertante

A 17th- or 18th-century piece with parts for solo instruments.

concerto

A large-scale piece for a solo instrument and an orchestra.

consonance

A chord or interval that sounds pleasing to the ear.

continuo

An accompaniment used in Baroque music, played on a keyboard and other bass instruments. Also called basso continuo.

contrabass

Any member of an instrument family that is lower in pitch than the bass instrument of the same type—for example, contrabass clarinet.

contralto

Another word for alto, but only used for female singers.

contrapuntal

Music that uses counterpoint.

counter melody

A secondary but subordinate melody that is played at the same time as a lead melody.